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The Harvest Festival

Sterling Castle, Norfolk, Autumn 1851

Scene 2 · The lower training yard

By two o'clock the festival had become a sound beyond the wall: the fiddle, and a drum now with it, and somebody's dog, and under everything the long contented murmur of a yard full of people eating. The lower training yard held all of it at a distance, the way a quiet room holds a party two floors down.

Niall was there before him. He was always there before him. He stood at the narrow table against the north wall with his coat folded on the bench behind him and the wooden box open, laying the practice knives out in a line, and he did not look round when Alexander came through the gate in his shirtsleeves with his cravat already in his pocket.

"You're late," Niall said.

"I was pushing a cart."

"So the kitchen tells me." He set down the fourth knife, square to the third. "The kitchen says you pushed it very well."

Five knives went down on the table, one after another, dull iron with leather wound about the grips, in the same straight line they had gone down in for six years. There had been six, once. The sixth lay in the drawer of Alexander's dressing case upstairs, wrapped in a sheet of paper on which Niall had drawn in pencil the way a hand should close on a grip, and neither of them had ever said one word about where it had gone. Niall had never replaced it. Every lesson the box held five, and every lesson Alexander saw the gap.

Niall was three inches the taller and broader through the shoulder, built for use and not for show, and he stood the way he always stood, with his weight a little forward, as though he expected at any moment to have to move. The wind coming up off the fields had got into his hair, which was the colour of a fox's back and never stayed where he put it. He wore the plain tweed and the muted waistcoat of his post in the Duke's private office. The corner of a notebook showed at his waistcoat pocket, as it always did; Alexander had never once seen him put it down anywhere.

"Seven paces," Niall said. "Elbow first."

Alexander took the first knife by the hilt and went to the chalk line. Seven paces from the old chestnut, which Niall had paced out himself in the first spring and could have told anyone the exact distance of in feet and inches if anyone had been fool enough to ask. The painted circle on the butt had been renewed so often that its rings had thickened like the rings of the tree. In the middle of it sat the dark knot he had been aiming at since he was sixteen.

He threw. The knife turned once and went in a hand's breadth low.

"Again."

He threw again, and again, and the yard settled into the sound it had made for six years: the thud, the walk, the pull, the walk back. Here he did not have to be anyone's heir. Here he could be bad at a thing and then less bad at it, and nobody stood in a line behind him.

On the fourth knife Niall said, "Your wrist, Alex," and came up beside him.

He took Alexander's wrist in his left hand, the one with the pale seam of an old scar across the palm, and set it straight. His thumb went to the heel of Alexander's hand, found the raw place where the splinter had come out that morning, and moved without a pause to the other side of the grip, where it would not press. He did not look at the mark. He did not say anything about it. He held the wrist a moment, set, and took his hand away a little before he needed to, as he always did. In the first year he had corrected Alexander's elbow with the flat of another knife and never once with his hand. Alexander could not have said when that had changed.

"Now," Niall said.

The knife went into the second ring, high and to the left, and stayed.

"Better," Niall said, which was the most he ever said.

He took his own turn at the line, the knife held loose beside his head, and then he did the thing Alexander had spent six years learning to read. He paused. It was the smallest thing, a breath held a beat too long before the release, and it meant that Niall was not looking at the target at all. He was looking past it, over the yard wall and the water-meadow, at the tree line on the far side. His eyes, a pale and ordinary blue when he was being dry at Alexander's expense, had gone entirely still. As Alexander watched, the rooks went up out of those trees in a black, complaining shower, and wheeled, and settled again.

Niall threw without looking at the chestnut. The knife went into the dark knot at the centre of the circle as if it had been sent for.

"If you mean to look at the trees all afternoon," Alexander said, "you might at least throw at them."

"Four hundred and ten yards."

"I didn't ask how far."

"You were going to."

"I was going to ask whether the forest had done something to offend you. It hasn't moved in living memory. I'm told it's a point of family pride."

Niall went to pull his knife. He did not answer, and he did not look back at the trees, which was how Alexander knew he was still looking at them. The rooks went up a second time while he was at the target, all at once, as though something had walked underneath them, and came down more slowly than before.

Alexander could have asked. He weighed the knife in his hand and found that he would rather needle a man for an hour than ask him one plain question and be told it was nothing.

"Sir," Niall said, and stepped back from the line.

It took Alexander a moment to understand. Then he heard the gate. Catherine came through it from the kitchen garden in the blue silk, its hem still muddied from the morning, with something white in each hand and the wind pulling her hair further down on one side.

"Lady Catherine," Niall said.

She had heard it, the change from one word to the other. Alexander saw her hear it, in the small check of her step, the way he had once seen her hear a wrong note in a piece she was playing and go on as though she had not.

"Don't stop on my account, Alex," she said. "I've come to give you each something, and then I'll go away and leave you to throw things at that poor tree." She held them out, one to each of them: two handkerchiefs of white lawn, and in the corner of each, in blue thread, a swallow with its tail spread. "For luck," she said, "since neither of you will ever go anywhere to need it."

"Thank you," Alexander said. "I think."

Niall looked at the swallow for a moment longer than he needed to. Then he folded the handkerchief in four, took the notebook from his waistcoat, and put it between two pages, the way he kept anything he meant to keep, and put the notebook back where it lived.

"Thank you, my lady," he said.

Alexander put his own into his pocket with the cravat. He was annoyed, without being able to say at what, and pleased, and he did not care to look closely at either.

Catherine was not looking at the handkerchiefs. She was looking at him, and then, briefly, at Niall, and then at him again, with an expression he had seen on her face before and had never been able to read. She did not say anything. She only smiled, a small private smile that was not meant for either of them, and tucked a lock of hair back that the wind took straight out again.

"Don't let him throw at Mr. Hodge," she said to Niall, "however much he deserves it," and went back the way she had come, and the gate swung shut behind her.

They threw until the hour was gone. Niall did not call him Alex again, and Alexander did not notice that he was waiting for it until he had stopped. The wind freshened. When the last knife was out of the chestnut, Alexander laid it in the box beside the others, pointing the way Niall had always pointed them.

"Tomorrow?" he said.

Niall looked at him, and then, past him, once more at the trees.

"Tomorrow, then."

He shut the lid on the five knives. Behind him, out beyond the water-meadow, the clouds had begun to come up out of the west.

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Added Details not in Scene Packet

Every detail in this scene that its scene packet does not supply, in the order it appears. Items marked *decided* have since been approved and recorded in the planning documents. Everything else is open to change in the next draft.

The yard

- At two o'clock the festival sound includes a drum and somebody's dog.
- Niall's coat is folded on the bench. "So the kitchen tells me."
- The box holds five knives. Alexander kept the sixth, from his first good throw, wrapped in Niall's pencil diagram, and Niall never replaced it. *(decided: Gap Resolutions, Part Five)*
- Niall's hair is "the colour of a fox's back." His notebook rides in his waistcoat pocket.
- The throwing line is at seven paces, which Niall paced out in the first spring. *(decided: Gap Resolutions, Part Five)*
- The painted rings on the chestnut have thickened with repainting "like the rings of the tree."

The lesson

- "Your wrist, Alex" is the book's first use of the name. *(decided: Gap Resolutions, Part Five)*
- Niall's thumb moves off the splinter wound without comment. *(decided: Gap Resolutions, Part Five)*
- In the first year Niall corrected him with the flat of another knife, never his hand (from the prequel).
- "Better," which was the most he ever said.
- Niall's eyes are "a pale and ordinary blue" until they go still.
- The rooks go up out of the far trees twice. *(decided: Gap Resolutions, Part Five)*
- "Four hundred and ten yards." "I didn't ask how far." "You were going to."
- The forest "hasn't moved in living memory... a point of family pride."

Catherine

- She comes through the gate from the kitchen garden.

- Niall says "Sir," then "Lady Catherine." She hears the change. *(decided: Gap Resolutions, Part Five)*
- "Don't stop on my account, Alex."
- The handkerchiefs are white lawn, each with a blue swallow, tail spread.
- Niall folds his in four into the notebook. (decided: Gap Resolutions, Part Five) He says "Thank you, my lady."
- "Don't let him throw at Mr. Hodge, however much he deserves it."
- Alexander lays the last knife pointing the way Niall always points them.
- Closing: the clouds come up out of the west.